

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TIMOR-LESTE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is honest that Timor-Leste has no landmark community victory to point to, and that its central question is unusual — not only whether a project harms a community, but whether it is a wise use of a young nation's dwindling petroleum wealth. So it is built not on community-against-nation but on the nation's own prudent interest, through the levers of a real democracy (the resource-governance debate, civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights), and names each in plain words.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Here the fight has an unusual character, because the great destructive project is bound up with **national pride and the nation's very survival**, and the deepest question is not only whether a project harms a community but whether it is a **wise use of a young nation's dwindling petroleum wealth**. Timor-Leste is Asia's youngest country, a poor but genuine and hard-won democracy born from a long and costly struggle for independence, whose economy rests almost entirely on offshore oil and gas — and whose main producing field **ceased output in 2024**, leaving the sovereign **Petroleum Fund** to be drawn down while the government pursues a vast petroleum-infrastructure scheme along the south coast. That scheme, known as **Tasi Mane**, would build a supply base, an oil refinery, an LNG plant, a highway, and airports across the length of the southern shore, to bring the country's own offshore gas **onshore** for processing on Timorese soil rather than piping it, as before, across the sea to Australia. It promises jobs and industry and national dignity; but it would take **well over a thousand hectares of community farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms**, has already displaced families in anticipation, and is judged by international economists and the country's own respected independent analysts to be **unlikely ever to recover its costs** — an expensive and doubtful bet on petroleum by a nation that economists have long urged to diversify.

A community in Timor-Leste works with real, strong levers, because it is a genuine democracy — and the distinctive path is not opposition to the nation but the nation's own prudent conscience. The **resource-governance debate** — whether the finite petroleum wealth is wisely spent — is a powerful, patriotic argument, and the country's own respected independent analysts judge the Tasi Mane scheme unlikely ever to recover its costs. **Civil society** is capable and respected. The **institutions** — parliament, the courts — genuinely work, through lawful, open, unifying advocacy. The **church** carries deep moral authority. And **land rights** protect the farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms the project would take. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The project is **wrapped in national pride and the promise of prosperity**, the country is **poor and desperate for revenue**, and **opposition can be cast as unpatriotic** — bringing the nation's gas onshore is seen by many as a matter of sovereignty and dignity, so to oppose the megaproject can be painted as opposing the nation's advancement, even as its people are displaced and its wealth spent on works that may never pay. And there is **no landmark victory** to promise. So aim for what these levers can deliver — development made wiser and juster, the finite wealth spent prudently, the land and the displaced protected, a doubtful bet questioned in the open — by claiming the national interest for wise stewardship, not by setting community against nation.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

The megaproject looks unstoppable, wrapped in pride, but it is a question a real democracy can weigh, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Timorese fight turns on the **resource-governance debate** (is this wise use of finite wealth?); on **civil society** and the **institutions** (parliament, courts); on the **church's** moral authority; and on **land rights**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and the wealth debate, claiming the national interest for wise stewardship, is the one that reframes the whole fight. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the project may waste the nation's finite wealth, the resource-governance debate is your sharpest lever** — a doubtful, cost-losing bet is a patriotic argument against, not for, the nation's advancement.
- **If it takes farmland, fishing grounds, or salt farms, land rights protect them** — and the displaced are the human core of the case.
- **If the institutions work, use them** — parliament and the courts genuinely function in this democracy.
- **If opposition could be cast as unpatriotic, reframe it** — stand as the nation's prudent conscience, holding the national interest and the community together, never against each other.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **frame the effort as the nation's own prudent interest — wise stewardship of finite wealth — never as community against nation**, and **use the open, working levers of a real democracy: the wealth debate, civil society, the institutions, the church, and land rights**. Anyone tempted to frame the fight as community against nation should understand that doing so hands the government its easiest victory.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how the project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The government drives the megaproject, and it is wrapped in national pride, so opposition must claim the national interest, not oppose it. But this is a **real democracy**: the **parliament** debates and appropriates the finite wealth, the **courts** genuinely function, **civil society** is capable, the **church** carries deep moral authority, and **land rights** protect the farmland and fishing grounds. Know which of these you can reach — the wealth debate and the institutions are the sharpest, in a country weighing its own future.

How the Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The petroleum-wealth decision. The Petroleum Fund is drawn down for the scheme. *Your opening — the reframing one:* the resource-governance debate — is this a wise use of finite wealth?

The parliament and the courts. *Your opening:* the institutions that appropriate the money and can review the decision.

The land and the displaced. *Your opening:* land rights protecting the farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms, and the human case of the displaced.

Civil society and the church. *Your opening:* the capable civil society and the church's moral authority, carrying the case to the nation.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **What it costs and whether it will pay** — because a doubtful, cost-losing bet against a drawn-down Petroleum Fund is the sharpest, most patriotic argument. **What it takes** — the thousand-plus hectares of farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms, and the displaced families — the human core. **Who judges it doubtful** — the international economists and the country's own respected analysts, whose credibility grounds the case.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **parliament** debates and appropriates the wealth. The **courts** can review the decision. **Civil society** and the country's **respected independent analysts** judge the economics. The **church** carries moral authority. And Timor-Leste's **communities, civil society, analysts, church, and open institutions** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition of a real democracy weighing its future.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, and there is no landmark win here. What most moves them: whether the wealth debate can be won in the open, whether the institutions engage, and whether the effort is framed as the nation's own prudent interest.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
The resource-governance / wealth debate	30–55%	months–yr	low	A doubtful bet questioned in the open
Engage the parliament	25–50%	months–yr	low	Scrutiny; a wiser appropriation
Court review of the decision	20–45%	months–yr	mod	A decision or land-taking reviewed
Assert land rights (the displaced)	25–50%	months–yr	low	Farmland/fishing/salt farms protected
Enlist civil society + respected analysts	30–55%	months–yr	low	Credible case built and carried
The church's moral authority	25–50%	months–yr	low	The nation's conscience engaged
Everything together (wealth debate, institutions, church, land)	35–60%	months–years	mod	Development made wiser and juster
Framing it as community vs nation	5–15%	—	—	Fails — hands the government its win

The levers that move the needle most are the **resource-governance / wealth debate** and the **institutions**, backed by **civil society, respected analysts, the church, and land rights**. There's no landmark ceiling to cite — and the clearest lesson is the honest floor: framing the fight as **community against nation** fails, because it lets the project be defended as the nation's advancement. So aim for development made wiser and juster, the finite wealth spent prudently, the land and the displaced protected, and a doubtful bet questioned in the open.

On cost: the wealth debate, engaging the institutions, enlisting civil society and analysts, and the church cost mainly organised, credible effort; litigation costs more. The great strength is a real democracy weighing its own finite wealth; the great requirement is the reframing — standing as the nation's prudent conscience, never against the nation.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the megaproject" is easily cast as unpatriotic. Being specific — this doubtful cost, this displaced village, this drawn-down Fund — and framing it as wise stewardship, is right. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and what does it cost? Name the project (Tasi Mane's refinery, LNG plant, highway, airports) and, crucially, **its cost and whether it will pay**, against the drawn-down Petroleum Fund.

2. What does it take? The **thousand-plus hectares of farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms**, and the **displaced families** — the human core of the case.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next opening? A petroleum-wealth appropriation, a parliamentary debate, a land-taking, a court review. These are the openings.

4. Who judges it doubtful — and how to frame it? The **international economists and the country's own respected analysts** who judge it unlikely to recover its costs — and the framing as the **nation's prudent interest**, not opposition.

5. Who's the coalition? **Civil society, respected analysts, the church, community leaders, and the institutions** — the open, unifying coalition of a real democracy. Not confrontation, but credible, patient work.

What this looks like in real life. A petroleum megaproject would spend the nation's dwindling savings on works economists judge unlikely to pay, while taking a thousand hectares of farmland and displacing families. The five questions yield: the doubtful cost against a drawn-down Fund (your sharpest, patriotic lever); the farmland and the displaced; a parliamentary appropriation or land-taking in play; the respected analysts who judge it doubtful; and an open coalition of civil society, the church, and the institutions. That's the Timorese pattern — claim the national interest for wise stewardship, and use the wealth debate, the institutions, the church, and land rights.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between an effort that can weigh the nation's wealth and one that can't is credible proof — of the economics, and of the harm. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the economics. The heart of it: document, with the **international economists and the country's own respected analysts**, the **cost and the doubtful return** — that the scheme is unlikely ever to recover its costs, against a Petroleum Fund being drawn down since the main field ceased output in 2024. This is the sharpest, most patriotic evidence.

Layer two: the human harm. Document the **thousand-plus hectares of farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms** the project would take, and the **displaced families**, with evidence and testimony — the human core, and the land-rights case.

Layer three: the framing and the coalition. Frame it all as the **nation's prudent interest** — wise stewardship of finite wealth — and map the coalition of civil society, analysts, the church, and the

institutions. Walking into the parliament, the courts, the church, or the nation with the credible economics, the human harm, and that patriotic framing is what makes them weigh the project honestly.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The economics** — the cost and the doubtful return, from international economists and the country's respected analysts.
- **The land taken** — the thousand-plus hectares of farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms, and the displaced families.
- **The Petroleum Fund position** — drawn down since the main field ceased output in 2024.
- **The credible judgements** — the respected analysts who judge the bet doubtful.
- **The coalition map** — civil society, analysts, the church, and the institutions.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; an open, unifying coalition — standing as the nation's prudent conscience — gives you the power a real democracy rewards. Build in four moves.

Frame it as the nation's prudent interest. The deepest Timorese truth: an effort framed as **community against nation** hands the government its easiest victory. Frame everything as the **nation's own prudent interest** — wise stewardship of finite wealth, protection of the land and the future — claiming the national interest, not opposing it.

Build the credible economic case with respected analysts. Enlist the **country's respected independent analysts and international economists** whose judgement that the scheme is unlikely to pay grounds the whole case. Credibility is decisive here.

Enlist civil society and the church. Bring in the capable **civil society** and the **church**, whose deep moral authority can carry the case to the nation as a question of conscience and prudence.

Engage the institutions, and protect the displaced. Use the **parliament** (which appropriates the wealth) and the **courts** (which genuinely function), and assert the **land rights** of those whose farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms are taken. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, and the patient, unifying endurance a real democracy rewards.

STEP 4: THE WEALTH DEBATE, THE INSTITUTIONS & LAND RIGHTS

Timor-Leste's sharpest levers weigh the nation's finite wealth in the open, through the institutions of a real democracy.

The Resource-Governance / Wealth Debate — the Reframing Lever

Your sharpest, most distinctive lever: the **resource-governance debate** — is this a wise use of a young nation's dwindling petroleum wealth? A scheme judged by economists and the country's own respected analysts unlikely ever to recover its costs, against a Petroleum Fund drawn down since 2024, is a **doubtful bet** — and questioning it is patriotic prudence, not opposition to the nation. This reframes the whole fight.

The Institutions — Parliament and the Courts

Use the working institutions of a real democracy: the **parliament**, which debates and appropriates the finite wealth, for scrutiny and a wiser appropriation; and the **courts**, which genuinely function, to review a decision or a land-taking.

Civil Society, the Church, and Land Rights

Enlist the capable **civil society** and the country's **respected analysts** to build and carry the credible case; the **church**, whose moral authority engages the nation's conscience; and **land rights** to protect the farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms, and the displaced families — the human core.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: these levers are real and strong in a genuine democracy, but the project is wrapped in pride, the country is poor and revenue-hungry, opposition can be cast as unpatriotic, and there's no landmark win. So use the levers — the wealth debate, the institutions, civil society, the church, and land rights — frame everything as the nation's prudent interest, and count development made wiser and juster, the wealth spent prudently, the land and the displaced protected, and a doubtful bet questioned in the open as real wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it — as prudence, not opposition.

A doubtful bet becomes patriotic prudence. Not "we oppose the project" but *"economists and our own respected analysts judge this unlikely ever to recover its costs — is this a wise use of our dwindling savings?"*

The displaced become the human core. *"This takes a thousand hectares of our farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms, and displaces families — for a bet that may never pay."*

The Petroleum Fund becomes a question of the future. *"Our main field ceased output in 2024, and our Fund is being drawn down — for works economists doubt will pay. What will be left for our children?"*

The institutions become the honest forum. *"Let the parliament and the nation weigh this openly — as the prudent stewards of our own wealth."*

Match it to the venue: the economics to the parliament, the analysts, and the nation; the land and the displaced to the courts and land-rights case; the conscience to the church; the framing always as the nation's prudent interest.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Timor-Leste, attention works best framed as prudence — the nation weighing its own finite wealth — and the church and respected analysts carry it far. A capable civil society and free press make the media front central, but the framing is everything.

Lead with the wealth and the future, not opposition. Not "the megaproject is bad" but "is spending our dwindling savings on works economists doubt will pay, while displacing our people, a wise use of the nation's wealth?" Use your strongest material: the credible economics, the displaced families, and the drawn-down Fund.

Work several audiences at once. Timorese civil society, the church, and the respected analysts build the national debate; international attention (economists, the resource-governance world) reaches the credible

judgement. Make it easy: clear economics, the human harm, the prudent framing.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit the credible case, and credibility is everything here. And never frame it as community against nation — always as the nation's prudent conscience.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — The wealth-debate case (to the parliament / public).

Subject: Is [project] a wise use of our finite wealth?

"We, [group], ask that [project] be weighed as a question of prudent stewardship: economists and our own respected analysts judge it unlikely to recover its costs, against a Petroleum Fund drawn down since 2024. [Attach the economics.]"

8B — Engaging respected analysts / economists.

Subject: The economics of [project].

"We ask your credible, independent assessment of whether [project] is a wise use of the nation's dwindling petroleum wealth: [specifics]. [Contact.]"

8C — Asserting land rights (the displaced).

Subject: Our land and [project] — [community].

"We, the community of [place], assert our rights over the farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms [project] would take, and speak for the families displaced: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — To the church.

Subject: A question of prudence and conscience — [project].

"We ask the church to weigh [project] as a matter of the nation's conscience and the wise stewardship of its finite wealth, and of justice to the displaced. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — Engaging civil society (the coalition).

Subject: Our nation's wealth and future — let's weigh it wisely.

"We propose an open, unifying effort to weigh [project] as the nation's prudent interest — the wealth debate, the institutions, the church, and land rights. Please join. [Contact.]"

8F — Court review (to a lawyer).

Subject: Reviewing the decision / the land-taking — [project].

"We seek to have [the decision / the land-taking for [project]] reviewed in the courts: [specifics]. We ask your advice. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: A young nation stakes its savings on a doubtful petroleum bet.

"Timor-Leste is spending its dwindling Petroleum Fund on a megaproject economists doubt will pay, displacing families and taking farmland. We can provide the economics, the harm, and the prudent case. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the nation (as prudent conscience).

Subject: Our wealth, our land, our future — let's be wise stewards.

"[Project] would spend our dwindling savings on a doubtful bet and take our land. This is not community against nation — it is the nation's prudent conscience. Let's weigh it wisely, together, through our institutions, our analysts, and our church. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Frame everything as the nation's prudent interest, never community vs nation (8E/8H).**
2. **Build the credible economic case with respected analysts (8A/8B).**
3. **Assert the land rights of the displaced (8C).**
4. **Engage the church's moral authority (8D).**
5. **Take the wealth debate to the parliament and, if needed, the courts (8F).**
6. **Carry the credible, prudent case to the nation and the world (8G).**

Even lean, those six weigh the nation's wealth as prudent stewardship — the Timorese template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Timor-Leste's field is tilted by national pride and revenue hunger, so plan for it.

When opposition is cast as unpatriotic. This is the central risk. Reframe: stand as the **nation's prudent conscience**, claiming the national interest for wise stewardship, never opposing the nation. Community against nation hands the government its win.

When the project is wrapped in sovereignty and dignity. Bringing gas onshore is felt as dignity. Honour that feeling, and argue on prudence: is a bet economists doubt will pay the wise way to secure the nation's future?

When the country is poor and revenue-hungry. Acknowledge the real need for revenue, and argue that a cost-losing megaproject, against a drawn-down Fund, is the wrong way to meet it — that diversification and prudence serve the nation better.

When there's no precedent. This is a young democracy without a landmark win. Build the case on the wealth debate, the institutions, the church, and land rights, and lay down the prudent stewardship that can

grow.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Timor-Leste has real concerns about the handling of its petroleum wealth and the megaproject's contracts, so this matters.

How to spot it. Petroleum-wealth decisions against the credible economics; contracts favouring the connected; land taken against the communities' interest; benefits to the connected while the Fund is drawn down and families are displaced.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Timor-Leste's audit and oversight bodies examine public money and conduct. The **parliament** appropriates and can scrutinise the wealth. The **courts** can review decisions. The **respected analysts and civil society** can expose a doubtful or captured deal, and the **church** can speak.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how a decision defied the credible economics, who benefits, what the Fund is spent on — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit bodies, the parliament, the courts, the respected analysts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the prudent wealth-debate case.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, framed as prudence. The credible economics build your case; the wealth debate reframes it; the displaced and the land are the human core; civil society, the church, and the institutions carry it; the nation weighs it. Together they multiply. One at a time, or framed as opposition, they fail.

Early on (weeks 1–8): frame the effort as the nation's prudent interest; build the credible economic case with respected analysts; document the land taken and the displaced; enlist civil society and the church.

In the thick of it (months–year+): take the wealth debate to the parliament and the nation; assert land rights and, if needed, seek court review; carry the case with the church and analysts.

The long haul (year+): sustain the open, unifying campaign; keep the coalition and the credible case ready; hold the line for development made wiser and juster, the wealth spent prudently, the land and the displaced protected, and a doubtful bet questioned in the open.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Weighing a great destructive project in Timor-Leste is unusual, because the project is bound up with national pride and the nation's survival, and there is no landmark victory to point to. Hold both truths. The distinctive path here is real: not community against nation but the nation's own prudent conscience — the resource-governance debate over the wise use of finite wealth, the capable civil society, the working institutions of parliament and courts, the church's moral authority, and the land rights of those whose farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms are taken. And the constraints are real: the project is wrapped in national pride and the promise of prosperity, the country is poor and desperate for revenue, opposition can be cast as unpatriotic, and there is no landmark win to promise.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Frame everything as the nation's own prudent interest — wise stewardship of dwindling wealth, protection of the land and the future — never as community against nation, because that framing hands the government its easiest victory. Build the credible economic case with the country's respected independent analysts and international economists: that a scheme unlikely ever to recover its costs, against a Petroleum Fund drawn down since the main field ceased output in 2024, is a doubtful bet, and questioning it is patriotic prudence. Assert the land rights of the displaced, and speak for the thousand-plus hectares of farmland, fishing grounds, and salt farms at stake. Engage the church's moral authority, and use the working institutions — the parliament that appropriates the wealth, the courts that genuinely function. Count development made wiser and juster, the wealth spent prudently, the land and the displaced protected, and a doubtful bet questioned in the open as real wins. That is the Timorese way — a community standing as its nation's prudent conscience. So can you.